

Rajapaksa now has to deliver. His first hurdle would be to secure a comfortable parliamentary majority at the general elections in April that wouldn't require him to cobble together a coalition. During his last term, he was forced to forge an alliance that saw him handing out 109 ministerial posts to members of his government and accepting expensive defectors from opposition parties.

Rajapaksa would also have to settle the longstanding grievances of the Tamil people, including the thirst for some form of self-governance. The indication, however, is that he's more likely to concentrate on development and economic initiatives rather than political aspirations. The All Party Representatives Committee that he appointed in 2007—and which, with several parties missing, isn't really an 'all party' body—to produce recommendations for a political solution is widely considered to be a front to pacify the international community. Nothing its members proposed so far has been implemented and Rajapaksa decisively said last year that he will only consider issues of devolution after the presidential election. Now, the moment has arrived.

Rajapaksa also has to fix the economy. Although the macro outlook is positive, the cost of living is soaring with expenditure on food and essential items eating into the monthly pay packet. (Ironically, one of the steps the government took during the election campaign was to approve a total cost of living allowance of Rs 5,250 for all state sector employees, to be added to their January salaries). Thus far, the Government has attempted to patch the holes by importing to bridge scarcities and by opening centres that sell products at cheaper prices. But the public would expect more than knee-jerk, piecemeal measures from the President they generously elected for a second term.

Inclusivity is another factor the President would have to concentrate on. If he wishes to be remembered as a post-war President who unified the

country after 30 difficult years of conflict, he would have to shed the Sinhala Buddhist nationalist image he has so carefully cultivated—apart from the few phrases in Tamil he delivers with the aid of a teleprompter during some public speeches. The outcome of the election is a clear sign that the minorities had backed Fonseka. The former general scored mostly in areas with significant ethnic and religious minorities, sweeping the north and parts of the east.

In a post-election statement, Rajapaksa touched upon this issue, designating himself the leader of all Sri Lankans whom he urges "to set aside their differences and to come together to help build the nation". But Sri Lankans have heard this before—if nothing else, Rajapaksa has a talented speech writer. He would be expected during his second term to put money where his mouth is, take

A SRI LANKAN TAMIL WOMAN VOTES AT A POLLING BOOTH IN COLOMBO



What India Seeks

India has welcomed Rajapaksa's victory. Now it expects him to:

- Focus on a political and economic package for the Tamil-speaking minority in the North and the East that would build their confidence and mitigate feelings of alienation.
- Move on the Comprehensive Economic and Partnership Agreement between the two countries that would boost trade and joint ventures.
- Ensure the primacy of India's strategic space in the region and make an effort to curb the growing influence of China and Pakistan in Lankan affairs.

all political parties to his fold and stop peppering public jobs with friends, relations and family members.

Rajapaksa's victory leaves the opposition in a shambles. The election proved that the JVP's vote base is notably eroded although the UNP is likely to have preserved—even reenergised—its block vote. But it will take months, perhaps years of reorganising, to get the Opposition back to fighting form. The future of Fonseka, who, despite his loss, scored respectably well at the election, is uncertain. Even if he does come forward as a viable face for the Opposition, he has no party and is notoriously difficult to manage. This would leave Rajapaksa all powerful and free to consolidate the dynasty he had been actively promoting. That would not bode well for any democracy. ■